2. WAR (LUIGI PIRANDELLO)

The story takes place in a dark, stuffy, and smoky second-class railway carriage travelling from Rome to Sulmona during the height of World War I. At Fabriano station, a bulky woman dressed in heavy black mourning clothes boards the carriage, supported by her husband. She is deeply grief-stricken because her twenty-year-old only son is being sent to the war front to fight. Her husband tries to comfort her and explains her plight to the other passengers in the carriage, hoping to receive their understanding and sympathy. However, the other passengers are also parents with children on the front lines, and the husband's explanation triggers a heated debate among them regarding whose personal sacrifice and emotional suffering is the greatest.

As the discussion progresses, various parents put forward their arguments to prove that their grief is superior. One passenger argues that parents who have multiple sons at the war front suffer much more because the threat of losing a child is multiplied across several lives. Another passenger refutes this claim, arguing that if a parent loses one out of two sons, there is still one surviving child left to live for and care about, whereas losing an only child leaves a parent in total despair without any remaining reason to go on living. The passengers become locked in this gloomy competition of grief, each trying to validate their own suffering as the most severe.

Suddenly, an old, stout man with bloodshot grey eyes interrupts the conversation with a passionate speech. He sternly tells the other parents that they should not treat their children as personal property or expect them to stay at home to take care of them in old age. He claims that young people naturally love their country more than their parents and that they march off to the front lines willingly and joyfully to sacrifice their lives for the honor of the nation. He argues that if young soldiers die happily while serving their country, parents should not wear mourning clothes or weep for them, but should instead feel proud and celebrate their glorious sacrifice. He discloses that his own son died happily in battle, leaving behind a letter stating he died satisfied, which is why he refuses to wear black or mourn.

The other passengers are completely silenced and awed by the stout man's supreme patriotic conviction and stoic philosophy, believing he has reached a higher level of courage and selflessness. The grieving mother in black, who had been sitting quietly in her own world of sorrow, is deeply struck by his words and looks closely at him. Wanting to confirm whether his extraordinary bravery is truly genuine, she turns to him and asks a simple, direct question: "Then... is your son really dead?" This naive question suddenly shatters the stout man's elaborate intellectual defense. He had used hyper-patriotism and philosophical arguments as a psychological shield to suppress his unbearable pain. Upon being confronted with the stark, irreversible reality of his son's death, his composure instantly crumbles, and he breaks down into uncontrollable, heartbreaking sobs in front of everyone.